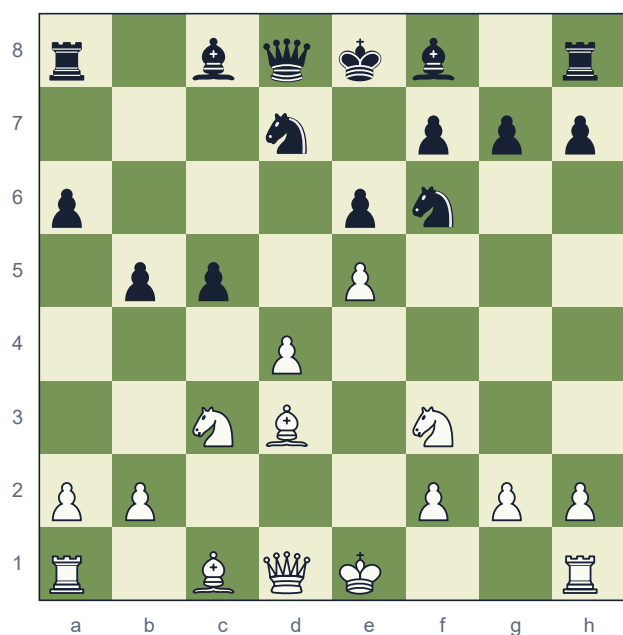


The Semi-Slav: e3 systems

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 e6 5.e3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Choose 5.e3 rather than making the sharp Bg5 systems mandatory. Develop Bd3 and decide how to meet Black's queenside expansion.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

Black's c6-d5-e6 triangle is solid but restrains the c8 bishop. The ...dxc4 and ...b5 sequence frees the queenside at the cost of time and dark-square concessions.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

The Meran uses ...dxc4, ...b5 and often ...a6 followed by ...c5. Waiting with ...Bd6 can lead to an Anti-Meran structure.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. The bishop goes to d3 after ...b5 in the Meran; do not leave it attacked on c4.
2. Central breaks e4 and ...c5 often decide whether a flank expansion was justified.
3. If Black plays ...f5, treat the result as a Stonewall structure rather than a normal Meran.

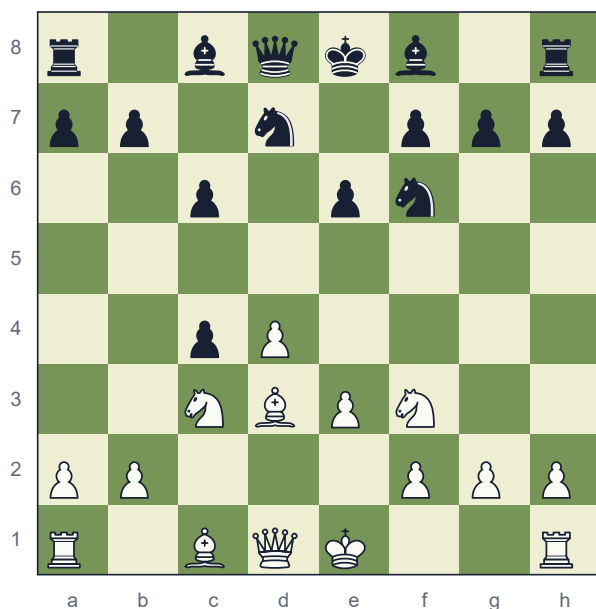
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Meran: the central counterstrike

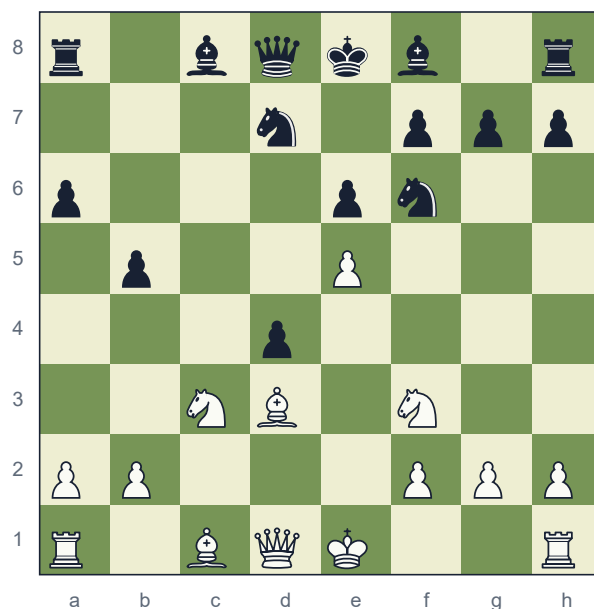
STUDY LINE 06-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4

Selected anchor ends with 10. e5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White gains time against the f6 knight while Black attacks the center. This is a concrete line: e5 is a central reaction to ...c5, not a generic attacking move.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Calculate captures on d4 and b5. Keep pieces active; the position can open before either side has completed the familiar quiet setup.

WATCH FOR

After 10.e5, stop and calculate Black's reply. This is a place to learn a branch rather than blindly finishing a ten-move script.

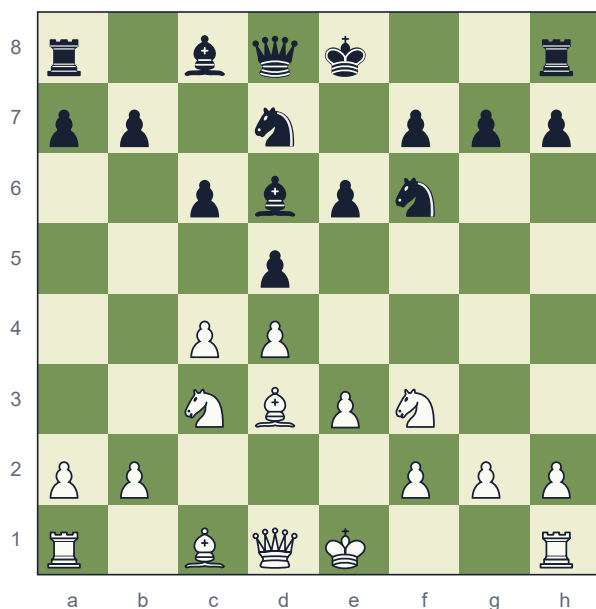
REMEMBER Answer a flank expansion with a prepared central action.

02 Anti-Meran with ...Bd6

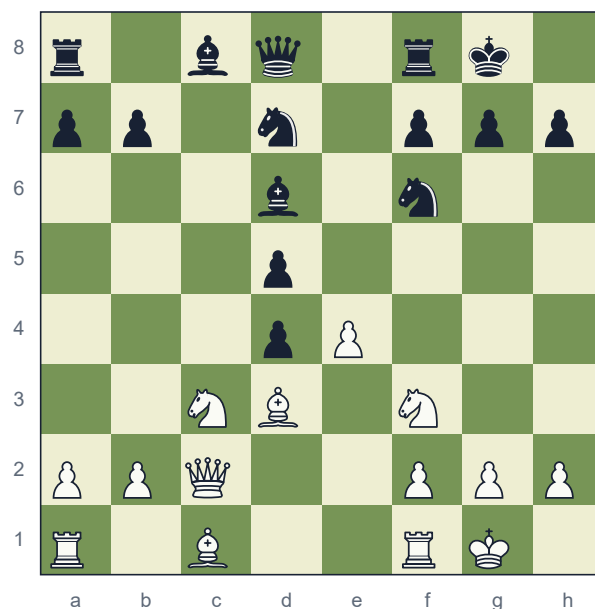
STUDY LINE 06-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 Bd6 7. O-O O-O 8. Qc2 e5 9. cxd5 cxd5 10. e4 exd4

Selected anchor ends with 8. Qc2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Qc2 reinforces e4 while castling removes your king from the center. Both players retain choices about the central tension.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Re1, e4 and queenside development are candidates. If Black captures c4 and pushes ...b5, retreat the bishop and strike centrally when ready.

WATCH FOR

e4 can fail if ...dxe4 and a tactical knight capture leave you losing a central pawn. Count the sequence.

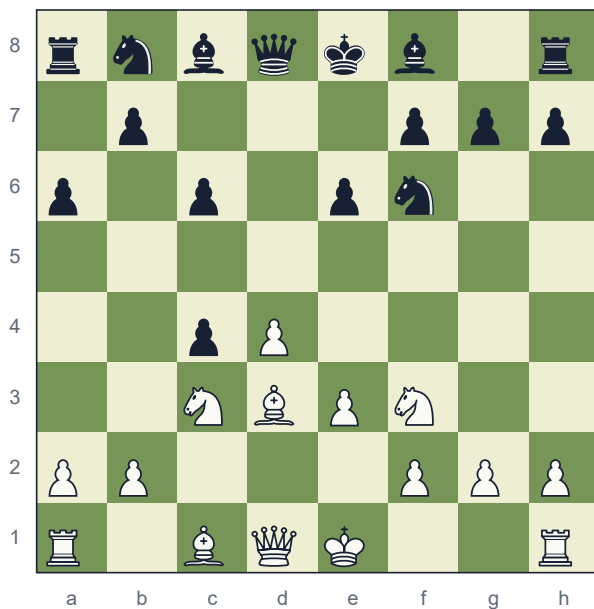
REMEMBER Prepare e4 with pieces, not just enthusiasm.

03 The early ...a6 Meran

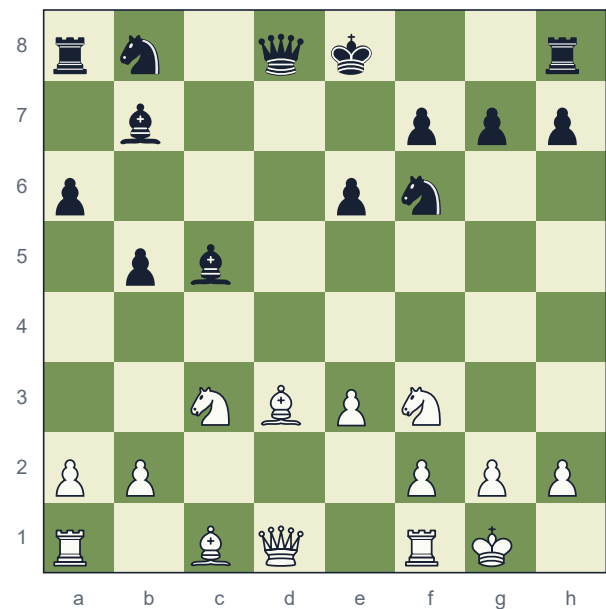
STUDY LINE 06-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 a6 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 c5 9. O-O Bb7 10. dxc5 Bxc5

Selected anchor ends with 9. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black delays the b8 knight and begins expansion. White castles before choosing a direct central confrontation.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

e4 is attractive if properly supported. Compare a quick e4 with keeping the center and improving the queen and rooks.

WATCH FOR

Do not assume every ...a6 line is identical: a knight on d7 changes tactical defenses and available breaks.

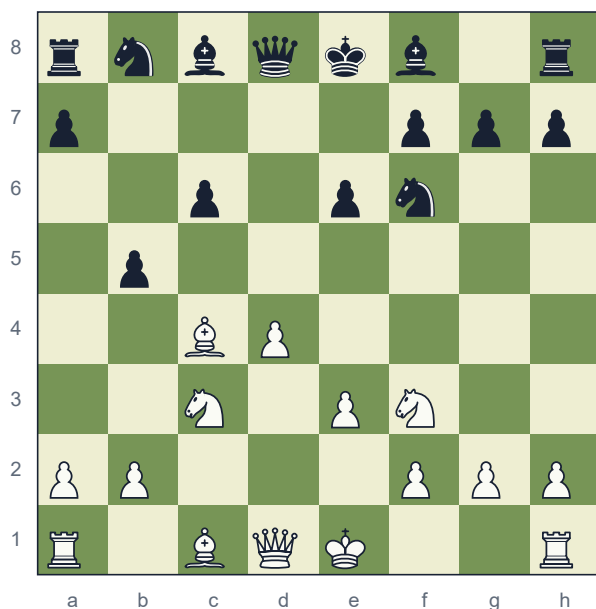
REMEMBER Notice which developing move Black has delayed.

04 Black exchanges on c4 before ...Nbd7

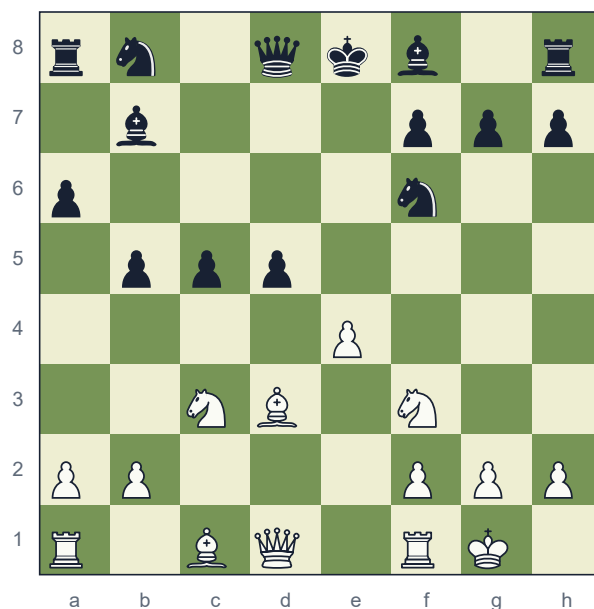
STUDY LINE 06-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 dxc4 6. Bxc4 b5 7. Bd3 Bb7 8. O-O a6 9. e4 c5 10. d5 exd5

Selected anchor ends with 8. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Bxc4 and Bd3 accept that a developing bishop may have to move twice. Black also spent time on a capture and a pawn push.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use e4 once the central support is sufficient. Watch the b7 bishop's diagonal toward g2 after any central exchange.

WATCH FOR

Opening the long diagonal without checking g2 can turn a routine center push into a tactical error.

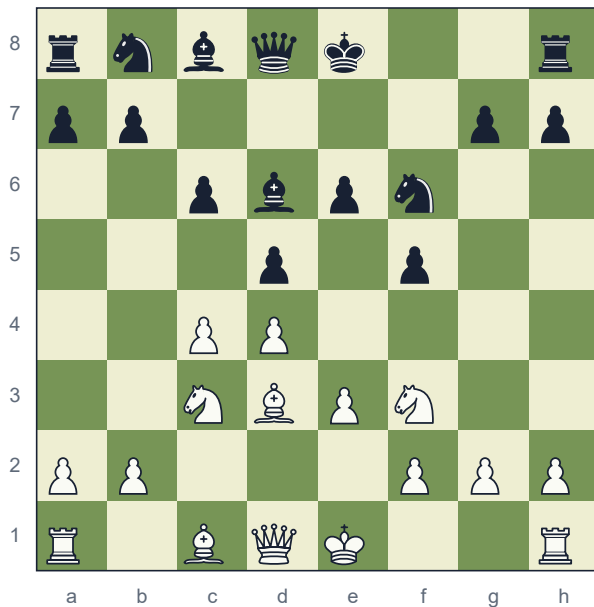
REMEMBER Track the b7-g2 diagonal before opening the center.

05 A Stonewall by ...f5

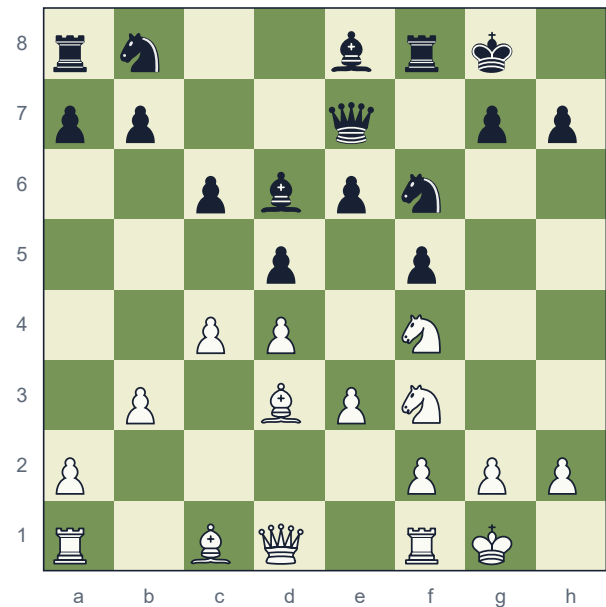
STUDY LINE 06-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 e6 4. Nc3 f5 5. e3 Nf6 6. Bd3 Bd6 7. O-O O-O 8. b3 Bd7 9. Ne2 Be8 10. Nf4 Qe7

Selected anchor ends with 8. b3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black fixes a Stonewall and gives up control of e5. b3 prepares a development route for the c1 bishop.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

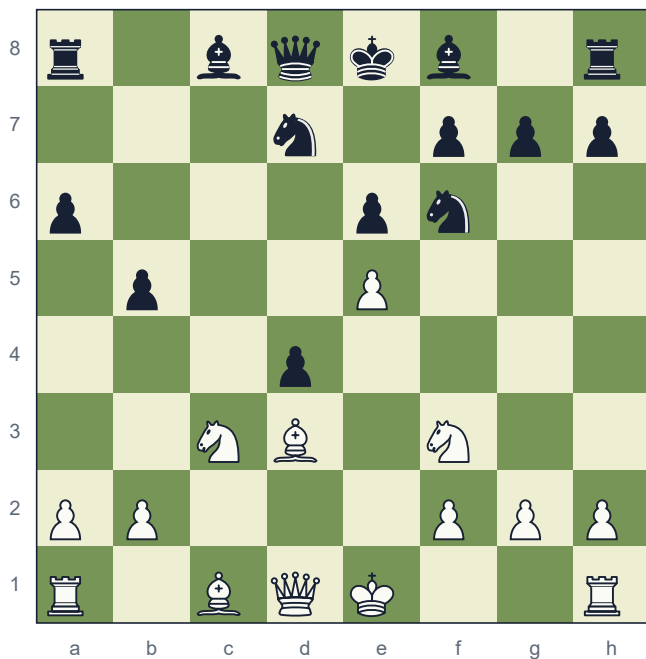
Bb2 or Ba3 may improve the bishop. Aim a knight at e5 and restrain ...g5 or ...Ne4 by controlling key entry squares.

WATCH FOR

If a black knight is already on e4, b3 may remove the only pawn defense of Nc3 and allow ...Nxc3. Verify that detail before using the bishop-development plan.

REMEMBER The e5 square is the strategic prize, but loose pieces come first.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

Black's c6-d5-e6 triangle is solid but restrains the c8 bishop. The ...dxc4 and ...b5 sequence frees the queenside at the cost of time and dark-square concessions.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

The Meran uses ...dxc4, ...b5 and often ...a6 followed by ...c5. Waiting with ...Bd6 can lead to an Anti-Meran structure.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Calculate captures on d4 and b5. Keep pieces active; the position can open before either side has completed the familiar quiet setup.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.